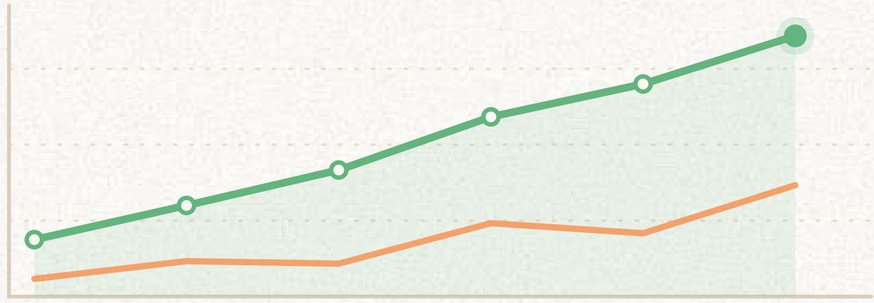
Lesson 2 · Writing

Vocabulary for trends.

ORANGE ENGLISH

The exact words examiners look for when data goes up, down, or nowhere at all.



WHY THIS MATTERS

Precise verbs make your description accurate.

Examiners reward **precise, varied language** . If every sentence says "went up" or "went down", your lexical resource score has a ceiling, no matter how accurate your data is.

in this lesson →

01 Describing an increase

02 Describing a decrease

03 Stability & fluctuation

04 Anchoring change in time

Describing an increase.

going up ↗️

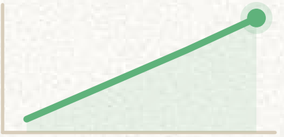
SLIGHT **rose slightly** · edged up · crept up

"Sales rose slightly in March."



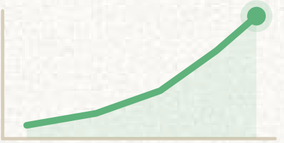
STEADY **increased steadily** · grew · climbed

"Profits grew steadily over the decade."



DRAMATIC **surged** · soared · rocketed

"Demand surged after 2018."

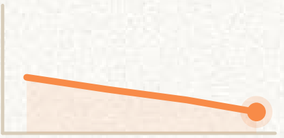


Describing a decrease.

going down ↘️

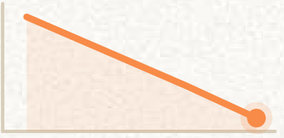
SLIGHT **dipped slightly** · eased back · edged down

"Prices eased slightly in Q2."



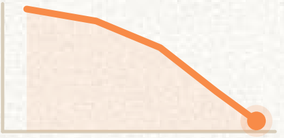
STEADY **declined steadily** · fell · dropped

"Membership fell steadily each year."



DRAMATIC **plummeted** · collapsed · nosedived

"Exports collapsed in 2020."



When the line doesn't go in one direction.

Stability

remained stable · levelled off · plateaued · stayed constant

"Numbers remained stable between 2015 and 2018."

Fluctuation

fluctuated · varied · rose and fell

"Prices fluctuated throughout the period."

a fluctuating trend



up, down, up, down, no clear direction

PART 3 · TIME EXPRESSIONS

Telling the examiner when it happened.

01

A single point

in 2010

at the start of the period

in 2020, not since 2020

02

A period

between 2010 and 2015

from 2010 to 2015

over the decade

03

An ongoing trend

throughout the period

over the course of the year

since 2020 (up to now)

04

Endpoint

by 2015

by the end of the period

by the final year

examiner mode

From vague to precise, one sentence.

✕ WEAK

"The number of users went up a lot between 2010 and 2020."

vague verb, no precision

✓ STRONGER

"The number of users **rose dramatically**, climbing from **2 million to 9 million** between 2010 and 2020."

precise verb + exact figures + clear time period

ACTIVITY *your turn!*

Sort the vocabulary.

Decide which type of movement each word describes. One word fits none of the three boxes: it is a fourth type.

surged | plummeted | plateaued | climbed | fell | fluctuated | soared | declined | remained stable

↗ INCREASE	↘ DECREASE	→ STABILITY

ACTIVITY *answer key*

How the words sort out.

There are four types of movement: increase, decrease, stability and fluctuation.

↗ INCREASE	↘ DECREASE	→ STABILITY
surged	plummeted	plateaued
climbed	fell	remained stable
soared	declined	

fluctuated the fourth type: **fluctuation**. The line goes up and down repeatedly, with no single direction.

KEY TAKEAWAYS

What to carry into your writing.

- **Vary your verbs**, don't repeat "went up / went down" for every graph.
- Match the adverb to the trend: **slightly, steadily,** or **dramatically**.
- Always **anchor the data in time**, using accurate time expressions.
- **Precision beats decoration**, one well-chosen verb outperforms a long sentence.

next up →

Grammar for Data Description